COMMUNICATION

Facilitator's Guide

DESCRIPTION	Utilize this facilitator's guide for: • Communication Video • Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques in Your Communication Resource Sheet • Modern Communication Methods/Tools for Effective Leadership
OBJECTIVES	Participants should be able to: • Understand best practices and barriers of effective communication • Understand how audience, tailoring your message, verbal/nonverbal communication and engaging in feedback contribute to effective leadership • Apply persuasion communication practices to be a more effective leader • Analyze different methods/tools to ensure effective communication
Time for Facilitation	Between 20 - 120 minutes

Introduction

Brief Starting Intro:

Communication is at the core of effective leadership. A leader's ability to convey ideas, set a clear vision, and align their team toward common goals is vital for success. Effective communication involves not only speaking clearly but also understanding the context, the audience, and the emotions involved. Leaders who excel at communication can inspire, motivate, and build trust, creating a culture where team members feel valued and heard. This, in turn, leads to higher engagement, better problem-solving, and improved overall performance. A leader's words can shape an organization's culture and set the tone for how employees interact with each other and approach their work.

Pre-Facilitation: Check with participants to see if they watched the video and read the resource articles. They should have both watched and read the resources prior to asking the following questions.

Best Practice Facilitation: Place participants into pairs of two so that they can share first with the other participant before sharing their answer with the whole group. This "pair and share" technique allows individuals to test out their answer(s) with someone else first (instilling confidence in the answer) and helps to start building stronger relationships with others in the program.

Depending on the time you have, select the questions that work within your schedule for training. Since we are utilizing the "pair and share" method, you should provide the participants with 2 minutes each to discuss their answers (let them know when to switch to keep them on time). Then have those who want to share their answers with the whole group a chance to do so (select 2 or 3 people to share - do not force participation). This can take up to 5 minutes. In total the pair and share technique for each question will take approximately 10 minutes. If you do not use the pair and share, allow 5-7 minutes for individuals to respond to the who group.

Communication General Questions

The following questions are based on the video:

1. In your opinion, what is the most difficult part of communication? Are there particular barriers you face when communicating with others? Who is someone professionally that you believe is an excellent communicator? What do they do that you admire about their communication process?
2. How much time do you spend thinking about the communication you have (or send out)? Are there particular audiences or people that you have a difficult time communicating with? Reflecting on this difficulty, how do you communicate with this person/audience? How would tailoring your message differently to this person/audience possibly change the way the message is received/shared?
3. What are the different ways that you communicate with others in your life? How do you know this is the right way to communicate with this audience? What audiences (or people) are you unsure of how they like to receive communication (which channel to use)? Do you have an example of a time when you used the wrong channel to communicate your message? What was the outcome? What channel should you have used to get a better outcome?
4. When considering best practices of communication, including being clear/concise, asking thoughtful questions, active listening, and not rushing the process, what area is your strength? Describe why this is a strength for you (provide an example). Which of the areas do you need to grow in to benefit your communication and your ability to share a message? What is one step you can take to grow in this area?

5. How often do you ask for feedback on your communication? What is one way, starting tomorrow you could establish a feedback loop to ensure you are consistently getting feedback to become a better communicator?

Additional Activity on General Communication:

1. Self-Assessment: Begin the workshop by providing participants with the communication self-assessment questionnaire provided. Encourage them to reflect on their current communication habits, strengths, and areas for improvement. Ask participants to rate their effectiveness in key areas such as clarity of communication, consistent messaging, and active listening.
2. Group Discussion: Facilitate a group discussion where participants share their self-assessment results and insights. Encourage open dialogue about common challenges and best practices in communication. Guide participants to identify common themes and patterns in their communication habits.
3. Advanced Analysis: To explore a more advanced analysis of communication shortcomings, break down the results further, have participants see what areas they excel or struggle in based on the following categories:
   - Questions # 1-5 Are focused on *General Communication*
   - Questions # 6-10 Are focused on *Clarity in Communication*
   - Questions # 11-15 Are focused on *Consistent Messaging*
   - Questions # 16-20 Are focused on *Listening in Communication*

Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques in Your Communication

Questions

The following questions are based on the Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques Article:

1. *After reading the Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques article (and focusing on the best practice of Reciprocity)*:
   a. How can leaders create opportunities to give before expecting something in return from their team members? Share an example from your experience.
   b. What are some specific ways you can recognize and reward team members to establish reciprocity?
2. *After reading the Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques article (and focusing on the best practice of Commitment and Consistency)*:
   a. What are some strategies you can use to encourage team members to make public commitments? Why might this be important for leadership?
   b. How can you set incremental goals to create a path for larger commitments? Give an example of how this has worked in your experience.
3. *After reading the Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques article (and focusing on the best practice of Social Proof)*:

   a. How can you leverage testimonials or endorsements to boost your team's morale and increase social proof?
   b. Can you describe a time when showcasing popular decisions or behaviors influenced your team's actions?
4. *After reading the Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques article (and focusing on the best practice of Authority and Experience)*:
   a. What are some ways to demonstrate authority and expertise in your leadership role? Share an example of how this has benefited your leadership.
   b. Why is it important for leaders to continuously develop their knowledge and skills? What impact does this have on your team's perception of you as a leader?
5. *After reading the Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques article (and focusing on the best practice of Liking)*:
   a. How can you build rapport with your team members to create a positive and cooperative environment? Share a personal experience.
   b. How does expressing appreciation and gratitude impact your team's perception of you? Provide an example of how this improved your team's morale or performance.
6. *After reading the Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques article (and focusing on the best practice of Unity)*:
   a. What types of shared experiences have you used to promote unity among your team? Which activities have been most effective in building a sense of camaraderie and collaboration?
   b. How do you foster a culture of collaboration instead of competition within your team? Discuss specific practices that encourage teamwork and discourage unhealthy competition among team members.
7. *After reading the Utilizing Effective Persuasive Techniques article (and focusing on the best practice of Narrative Persuasion)*:
   a. How do you use stories to communicate with your team? Share an example of a story you've told that helped influence your team's beliefs or behaviors.
   b. What methods do you use to encourage storytelling among your team members? Describe how these stories have contributed to a sense of community and strengthened team relationships.

Additional Persuasion-Communication Activity:

1. Case Study: Divide participants into small groups and provide each group with a case study on persuasive communication (Below are 7 case studies created to explore the 7 persuasive communication best practices covered in the article).
2. Analyze the Case Study: Have the participants in groups determine which persuasive communication technique is being discussed in the case study and answer the questions at the end of the case study.
3. Advanced Analysis: After analyzing the case study and discussing the questions, ask participants to work in their small groups to create a plan for incorporating that particular persuasive communication best practice into a real life leadership scenario they are dealing with currently. This could involve outlining specific actions, considering potential benefits and challenges, and determining how to measure success. Once the

plans are completed, groups can share their ideas with the larger group, encouraging discussion and collaboration on effective leadership practices.

Modern Communication Questions

The following questions are based on the Time Blocking Best Practice Article:

1. What are some best practices for using email effectively in your organization, and how do you ensure that important messages are not lost or overlooked in employees' crowded inboxes?
2. How do you balance the need for formal written communication with the risk of causing email fatigue among your employees? Can you share examples of when email was particularly effective or ineffective in your leadership experience?
3. How do you decide when to use text, instant messaging, or chat platforms versus more formal communication tools like email or in-person meetings? Can you describe a situation where instant messaging significantly improved team coordination or response time?
4. What strategies do you use to foster a sense of community and collaboration through instant messaging and chat platforms without compromising professionalism and focus?
5. How have internal social media platforms impacted communication and collaboration within your team or organization? Can you provide an example of a successful initiative or project that was facilitated by these platforms?
6. Considering the various communication tools discussed (email, instant messaging, internal social media), what best practices have you found most effective in ensuring clear, respectful, and productive communication within your team?

Additional Active Communication Activity:

1. Ask participants to bring in three emails they wrote to three different people over the last week.
2. Break participants into groups of two and ask them to exchange the emails they brought to the training.
3. Ask the participants to look over the email and utilize what they know or learned in the training to improve upon the emails. (5 minutes)
4. Once they have looked over the emails ask them to share feedback with their partners.
5. Finally, share general comments that individuals found insightful or interesting with the entire group.

General Communication Self Assessment

Instructions: Please rate each statement on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 indicates "Strongly Disagree" and 5 indicates "Strongly Agree."

1. I communicate my vision and goals clearly to my team.

1 2 3 4 5

2. I provide regular feedback and updates on progress.

1 2 3 4 5

3. I maintain open communication channels for my team to reach me.

1 2 3 4 5

4. I actively encourage questions and discussions among team members.

1 2 3 4 5

5. I communicate in a way that fosters a positive team culture.

1 2 3 4 5

6. I avoid using jargon or ambiguous language when addressing my team.

1 2 3 4 5

7. I provide examples or visuals to clarify complex concepts.

1 2 3 4 5

8. My team understands my instructions without needing frequent clarifications.

1 2 3 4 5

9. I ensure that my written communication (e.g., emails, memos) is clear and easy to understand.

1 2 3 4 5

10. I seek feedback from my team to ensure they understand my communication.

1 2 3 4 5

11. I maintain consistent messaging across all communication channels (e.g., meetings, emails, one-on-one interactions).

1 2 3 4 5

12. My team understands my priorities and objectives without confusion.

1 2 3 4 5

13. I follow through on what I communicate to my team.

1 2 3 4 5

14. I ensure that my communication aligns with the organization's values and mission.

1 2 3 4 5

15. I clarify any inconsistencies in messaging promptly.

1 2 3 4 5

16. I actively listen to my team's feedback and concerns.

1 2 3 4 5

17. I use non-verbal cues to show that I am engaged in conversations (e.g., eye contact, nodding).

1 2 3 4 5

18. I give my team undivided attention during meetings and discussions.

1 2 3 4 5

19. I encourage open dialogue and create a safe space for my team to express their opinions.

1 2 3 4 5

20. I follow up on feedback from my team to ensure I understood their perspective.

1 2 3 4 5

Scoring: Calculate your total score by adding up the ratings for each statement. A higher score indicates stronger time management skills and habits.

Total Score: _____

Interpretation:

- **85-100**: You have excellent communication skills and actively listen to your team. Keep up the great work!
- **70-84**: Your communication skills are good, but there's room for improvement in some areas. Focus on the lower-scoring sections to enhance your effectiveness.
- **55-69**: Your communication skills need improvement. Take note of the areas with lower scores and develop strategies to address them.
- **Below 55**: Your communication skills require significant improvement. Consider seeking feedback from trusted colleagues and focusing on developing communication and listening skills.

Scenario Overview #1:

Martin Rivera is the manager of a software development team at a mid-sized technology company. The team has been struggling with low morale and high turnover due to a demanding project schedule and recent layoffs. Martin is determined to turn things around. To achieve this, Martin implements several strategies designed to offer support, recognize contributions, and create opportunities for growth. Martin encourages team members to attend industry conferences and participate in training sessions relevant to their roles. He recommends specific employees for advanced projects and even arranges internal presentations where they can showcase their knowledge. By creating these opportunities, Martin aims to boost morale and increase team members' sense of value.

Additionally, to boost team spirit, Martin establishes a monthly "Developer of the Month" award, recognizing individuals who have made significant contributions to the team. The award is presented during team meetings, with a personalized plaque and a small bonus. He also highlights their achievements in the company newsletter, reinforcing the sense of appreciation and public acknowledgment.

Finally, Martin institutes regular one-on-one meetings with each team member to discuss their professional goals, challenges, and personal needs. He offers to mentor those interested in career advancement and actively helps resolve issues affecting their work-life balance, like allowing flexible work hours or remote work when needed.

In this scenario, what persuasion technique is Martin using to influence his team? What risks or challenges could arise from Martin's approach? How can you, as an effective leader, apply similar strategies to establish success within your team?

Scenario Overview #2:

Angela Thompson is a team leader in a marketing department at a large retail company. Her team is responsible for developing and executing digital marketing campaigns for various product lines. Recently, the team has experienced challenges with inconsistent performance, missed deadlines, and a lack of cohesion. Angela decides to address these issues by strengthening the team's accountability and working to improve goal achievement. To achieve this, Angela establishes a series of small, achievable goals for each team member as part of a broader campaign plan. These goals are designed to build confidence and demonstrate progress over time. She also encourages each team member to share their goals with the rest of the team during weekly meetings, reinforcing the commitment to the group.

Additionally, to create a sense of shared accountability, Angela introduces a project management tool where team members can publicly track their progress toward their goals. This transparency helps to maintain consistency and encourages individuals to follow through on their commitments. Angela also organizes regular check-ins to discuss progress and address any obstacles.

Finally, to reinforce positive behavior, Angela starts celebrating team members' achievements when they meet or exceed their goals. She hosts monthly team lunches to recognize those who have consistently met their commitments, and she encourages team members to congratulate one another on their successes. This public acknowledgment creates a positive atmosphere and motivates others to meet their commitments.

In this scenario, what persuasion technique is Angela using to influence her team? What risks or challenges could arise from Angela's approach? How can you, as an effective leader, apply similar strategies to establish success within your team?

Scenario Overview #3:

Laura Evans is the director of a technology team at a large financial institution. Her team has been slow to adopt a new project management software that the company recently implemented. Despite its proven benefits, some team members resist the change, preferring their familiar methods. To encourage adoption, Laura decides to demonstrate the software's effectiveness and persuade her team to embrace it.

Laura takes several actions to promote and encourage wider adoption of the new software including identifying a group within her department that has successfully adopted the new software and uses their success story to persuade others. She shares their experiences in a company-wide email, highlighting how the software improved their productivity and reduced errors. This sets a positive example for other teams.

In addition, Laura gathers testimonials from key stakeholders and clients who have benefited from the team's use of the new software. These testimonials are included in presentations, newsletters, and team meetings to emphasize the software's value. This external validation boosts the perceived credibility of the software and encourages team members to try it. To further encourage adoption, Laura points out that most teams in the company have already embraced the software and are reaping its benefits. She shares usage statistics showing that a significant majority have switched to the new system. This creates a sense of "joining the crowd" and reduces resistance to change.

In this scenario, what persuasion technique is Laura using to influence her team? What risks or challenges could arise from Laura's approach? How can you, as an effective leader, apply similar strategies to establish success within your team?

Scenario Overview #4:

John Stevens is a senior project manager at a software development company. His team is tasked with implementing a new project management framework, but there's considerable resistance from some team members who are used to the old way of working. To gain their buy-in and establish his authority, John invests time in learning about the latest project management techniques and tools. He attends industry conferences, completes online courses, and subscribes to industry journals. He then shares this knowledge with his team during meetings and training sessions, showing that he's committed to staying updated and providing them with valuable insights.

To support the new framework's implementation, John frequently cites reputable industry sources. During team meetings, he refers to studies and data that validate the new approach's effectiveness. This use of reliable sources bolsters his credibility and reduces skepticism among the team. Finally, John begins a mentorship program within his team, offering one-on-one sessions to discuss the new framework and address any concerns. By taking the time to guide and coach his team members, John positions himself as a trusted expert who is willing to invest in their success.

In this scenario, what persuasion technique is John using to influence his team? What risks or challenges could arise from John's approach? How can you, as an effective leader, apply similar strategies to establish success within your team?

Scenario Overview #5:

Sarah Green is the manager of a customer service team at a large e-commerce company. The team has experienced high turnover and low employee morale due to the demanding nature of the job and constant customer complaints. Sarah believes that building stronger relationships with her team and fostering a sense of camaraderie can improve morale and reduce turnover. She makes it a point to get to know her team members on a personal level. She asks about their families, hobbies, and interests, and remembers these details for future conversations. By showing genuine interest in their lives, Sarah builds rapport and creates a sense of connection with her team.

Additionally, Sarah consistently acknowledges and thanks her team members for their hard work. She starts each team meeting by recognizing individual achievements and expressing gratitude for their dedication. This regular appreciation makes her team members feel valued and contributes to a positive work environment.

Finally, to create a more relaxed and friendly atmosphere, Sarah shares personal stories and uses humor during team meetings. She often recounts amusing anecdotes from her past experiences in customer service, which helps her team see her as approachable and relatable. This use of humor lightens the mood and reduces stress among the team.

In this scenario, what persuasion technique is Sarah using to influence her team? What risks or challenges could arise from Sarah's approach? How can you, as an effective leader, apply similar strategies to establish success within your team?

Scenario Overview #6:

David Thompson is the director of a accounting department at a major insurance company. His team has recently undergone significant changes due to a company reorganization, resulting in a mix of new and experienced team members. These changes have led to a lack of cohesion and increased competition among team members, affecting the department's overall performance. David decides to address these issues by developing a clear and compelling vision for the department, emphasizing the importance of teamwork and shared goals. He articulates this vision during team meetings and in departmental communications, ensuring that each team member understands how their role contributes to the larger mission. He also aligns the vision with the company's core values to create a sense of unity across the organization.

Furthermore, to build camaraderie and strengthen relationships, David organizes regular team-building activities and retreats. These events focus on collaboration and cooperation, such as group challenges, problem-solving exercises, and outdoor adventures. By engaging in these shared experiences, team members develop a sense of unity and trust.

David also shifts the departmental culture from one of competition to one of collaboration. He establishes team-based goals and rewards collaborative efforts, rather than individual achievements. He also encourages team members to support each other’s successes and work together to overcome challenges. This approach helps reduce friction and promotes a more supportive environment.

In this scenario, what persuasion technique is David using to influence his team? What risks or challenges could arise from David's approach? How can you, as an effective leader, apply similar strategies to establish success within your team?

Scenario Overview #7:

Monica Johnson is a department head at a large consulting firm. The company is undergoing significant restructuring, causing uncertainty and anxiety among employees. Many team members are unsure about their roles in the new organizational structure and worry about their career stability. Monica recognizes the need to alleviate concerns, inspire her team, and reinforce a sense of shared purpose. Monica begins to share personal stories from her own career journey, recounting her experiences of overcoming obstacles and embracing change. She tells stories of times when she faced uncertainty and how it led to growth and new opportunities. By doing this, she establishes a personal connection with her team and encourages them to see change as a pathway to success.

Additionally, Monica uses narratives to highlight the company's core values and how they are being upheld during the restructuring. She shares stories of other teams and individuals who have embraced the new structure and found success, reinforcing the company's vision. This alignment helps her team understand how the changes fit into the broader organizational goals.

Finally, Monica creates an open forum during team meetings where members can share their own stories of success, challenges, and lessons learned. She encourages participation by offering recognition for those who share and creates a supportive environment where everyone feels comfortable expressing their experiences. This practice helps build a sense of community and shared understanding.

In this scenario, what persuasion technique is Monica using to influence her team? What risks or challenges could arise from Monica's approach? How can you, as an effective leader, apply similar strategies to establish success within your team?